Evaluative Monitoring and Threshold Models of Positive Affect Access

Florian Morin
Independent Researcher
florianmorin.com

June 2, 2026

Abstract

Many adults report reduced access to intense positive experiences associated with childhood, including vivid positive affect, emotionally moving experiences, and realistic imagery. This framework proposes that these capacities do not disappear but become increasingly constrained by evaluative monitoring.

A brain regime model is proposed in which access to positive experience depends partly on transitions between monitoring configurations. Three exercise families, suspension, openness, and salience, are introduced as methods intended to reduce evaluative load while minimizing anticipation, comparison, and optimization processes that may increase monitoring.

The framework predicts that successful transitions produce a recognizable experiential cluster including chest pleasure, being moved, vivid imagery, and realistic reactivation of previously encoded positive experiences.In particular, simple environmental stimuli or small objects are predicted to trigger disproportionately rich reactivation of previously encoded experiences, potentially reflecting less constrained memory retrieval processes.

The central claim is not that positive experience fades with age, but that access conditions change as monitoring increases.

Introduction

Many adults report that certain forms of positive experience, often associated with childhood, appear less accessible with age: intense positive affect, vivid imagery, strong emotional resonance from ordinary stimuli, and spontaneous reactivation of meaningful memories. Population-level findings suggest that aspects of internally generated experience, including imagery vividness and episodic richness, may change across the lifespan, although the mechanisms underlying these changes remain unclear (Gulyás et al., 2025; Addis et al., 2008). The present framework proposes that these capacities may not disappear, but instead become increasingly gated by evaluative monitoring processes.

The experimental probe paradigm was developed as an attempt to reduce monitoring pressure through structured reductions in evaluative load. The intervention protocol used throughout this paper is referred to here as the Morin Z-Reduction Task (M-ZRT), a structured procedure designed to minimize evaluative load while preserving behavioral engagement. The task is organized around three exercise families: openness, salience, and suspension. The framework is motivated primarily by repeated within-subject observations of discontinuous transitions rather than controlled experimental data.

Importantly, these exercise families are intentionally separated in space and context. Openness and salience exercises are performed outside video game environments and are intended to occur during a limited, predefined moment of the day rather than being distributed across daily life. This constraint exists because repeated spontaneous deployment throughout the day may encourage comparison processes, anticipation, active search for opportunities to perform exercises, or monitoring of environmental compatibility. These processes are predicted to increase evaluative load (Z) and therefore interfere with access conditions.

Suspension exercises differ operationally. They are embedded directly within first-person shooter gameplay environments, where unpredictability, rapid state changes, transient events, and continuous task engagement may reduce the stability of evaluative control. Suspension exercises therefore aim to disrupt evaluative continuity from within an ongoing task rather than outside of it.

Conceptually, the three families target partially distinct processes. Suspension exercises attempt to interrupt evaluative continuity and reduce corrective momentum. Openness exercises attempt to maintain unrealized alternatives, incomplete representations, or unresolved possibilities without immediate closure. Salience exercises attempt to transiently assign importance to stimuli without requiring explicit justification, optimization, or sustained attention.

The framework predicts that successful entry may produce a recognizable experiential cluster rather than isolated effects. Predicted phenomena include intense positive affect, increased perceptual vividness, experiences sometimes described as being moved or somatically salient positive affect, and richer internally generated imagery. In particular, the framework predicts that ordinary stimuli, including small objects, corners of rooms, textures, or irrelevant environmental details, may trigger unusually rich reactivation of previously encoded experiences from sparse cues. This may reflect less constrained retrieval or pattern-completion processes under permissive conditions rather than changes in reward intensity alone (Norman and O'Reilly, 2003; Yassa and Stark, 2011).

The central prediction is therefore not simply increased pleasure. It is the re-emergence of an experiential regime characterized by reduced evaluative capture, stronger positive affect accessibility, and richer access to previously encoded experience.

1 Neural Interpretation of Evaluative Monitoring and Regime Entry

The present framework does not assume a single anatomical locus for evaluative monitoring. Instead, monitoring is treated as an emergent function arising from interactions between salience allocation systems, action-selection networks, conflict monitoring circuits, and memory systems rather than a localized process (Bush et al., 2000; Shenhav et al., 2013).

Anterior cingulate cortex (ACC) activity is used here as a mechanistic anchor because of its established involvement in conflict monitoring, performance evaluation, action updating, effort allocation, and control arbitration (Bush et al., 2000; Shenhav et al., 2013; Holroyd and Yeung, 2012). Within the present framework, elevated monitoring load (Z) corresponds not to ACC activity alone, but to increased coupling between monitoring systems and downstream valuation processes. This interpretation is consistent with the proposal that positive affect collapse may occur when evaluative loops repeatedly re-enter ongoing experience rather than when reward signals themselves disappear.

At the network level, salience systems may influence whether incoming stimuli remain transient perceptual events or are rapidly recruited into evaluative processing. Under high-monitoring conditions, salience may preferentially trigger corrective, predictive, or action-oriented loops. Under permissive conditions, salience may instead propagate into valuation and memory systems with reduced interruption.

Action-selection systems are predicted to play a central role because evaluative capture often manifests phenomenologically as increased next-action pressure, preparation, correction, or optimization. In this interpretation, regime entry partially reflects temporary decoupling between perception and immediate action selection, allowing stimuli to remain salient without obligatory correction or behavioral updating.

The framework further predicts increased accessibility of pattern-completion processes within memory systems. Small environmental cues, ordinary objects, or weak perceptual fragments are predicted to trigger richer reactivation of previously encoded experiences from sparse cues. This mechanism may involve memory retrieval and pattern-completion processes becoming less constrained by evaluative filtering, allowing sparse cues to recruit richer affective-perceptual reactivation (Norman and O'Reilly, 2003; Yassa and Stark, 2011). The framework does not assume that such processes are specific to a single neural system.

Rather than proposing isolated regional changes, the framework therefore treats regime entry as a transient network reconfiguration characterized by reduced evaluative coupling, lower corrective momentum, altered salience routing, and increased accessibility of memory retrieval dynamics.

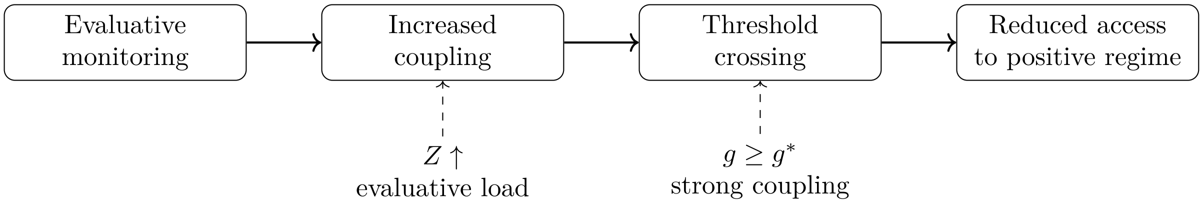

Figure 1: Proposed mechanism linking evaluative monitoring to reduced access. Increased evaluative monitoring raises evaluative load (Z), strengthens coupling between perception, evaluation, and action selection (g), and increases the probability of crossing the threshold into an evaluation-dominant regime. Above threshold, access to the permissive positive-affect regime is reduced.

Testable predictions.

- Increased monitoring load should predict reduced probability of threshold transitions even when reward magnitude is unchanged.
- Behavioral manipulations that transiently reduce evaluative coupling should increase access probability without requiring stronger rewards.
- Successful transitions should produce discontinuous rather than linear changes in subjective intensity and duration.
- Sparse environmental cues should produce disproportionately rich memory reactivation from weak cues during permissive states relative to high-monitoring states.
- Repeated measurement, optimization, or explicit tracking during induction should reduce entry probability by increasing evaluative coupling.

2 Potential Clinical Relevance

The present framework is not proposed as a diagnostic model or a general account of psychopathology. Instead, it is offered as a mechanistic hypothesis for conditions in which positive experiences appear cognitively accessible or explicitly valued but remain difficult to enter, sustain, or subjectively experience.

If evaluative monitoring acts as an upstream constraint on affective access, broad downstream effects may emerge across multiple domains without requiring impairment of reward systems themselves.

Positive affect accessibility and anhedonia. Many individuals with depression or anhedonia report preserved knowledge that activities remain valuable while simultaneously experiencing reduced affective access. This dissociation is compatible with the possibility that valuation systems remain partially functional while access conditions become increasingly constrained (Berridge and Robinson, 2003; Treadway and Zald, 2011).

Within the present framework, reduced positive affect accessibility may arise from multiple mechanisms rather than a single deficit. One possibility involves impaired reward generation. Another possibility involves excessive evaluative coupling, where reward-related signals remain present but repeatedly fail to transition into sustained positive experience because monitoring processes rapidly re-engage.

This interpretation generates a testable prediction: manipulations that transiently reduce evaluative load, without increasing reward magnitude, may increase access probability in at least a subset of individuals.

Age-related changes in positive affect accessibility. A common subjective report across adulthood is that childhood-like positive experiences become less accessible despite preserved cognitive function and intact autobiographical memory. Age-related changes in imagery vividness and internally generated experience suggest that some aspects of experiential richness may change across the lifespan, although underlying mechanisms remain debated (Gulyás et al., 2025; Addis et al., 2008).

The present framework predicts that age-related changes in affective accessibility may partly reflect increasing monitoring density rather than irreversible reductions in positive capacity. Greater future planning demands, stronger performance tracking, persistent self-observation, and chronic evaluative contexts may progressively elevate transition thresholds.

This interpretation predicts increasing difficulty of entry with age while preserving the possibility of transient recovery under permissive conditions.

High-monitoring states and chronic evaluative load. States characterized by persistent evaluation, repetitive correction, anticipation, or sustained performance pressure may maintain elevated monitoring load over time.

Under the present framework, prolonged exposure to evaluative contexts may stabilize evaluative coupling, potentially reducing access probability even outside the original context in which monitoring emerged.

This interpretation predicts that recovery from chronic evaluative states may lag behind removal of external stressors because access conditions themselves may remain temporarily altered.

Clinical predictions.

- Individuals with higher self-monitoring traits may show lower transition probability.
- Positive affect accessibility may dissociate from explicit value judgments.
- Reduced-monitoring manipulations may preferentially affect subgroups characterized by elevated evaluative load.
- Transition signatures may remain discontinuous rather than linear.
- Repeated measurement during induction may selectively impair access in high-monitoring populations.

Importantly, these proposals should be interpreted as mechanistic hypotheses regarding affective accessibility rather than established clinical claims.

Clinical predictions.

- Individuals with high self-monitoring traits may show reduced access probability.
- Positive affect accessibility may dissociate from explicit value judgments.
- Reduced-monitoring manipulations may preferentially affect subgroups characterized by elevated evaluative load.
- Transition signatures may remain discontinuous rather than linear.
- Repeated measurement during induction may selectively impair access in high-monitoring populations.

Importantly, these proposals should be interpreted as mechanistic hypotheses regarding affective accessibility rather than established clinical claims.

Clinical predictions.

- Individuals with high self-monitoring traits should show lower entry probability.
- Positive affect accessibility may dissociate from explicit value judgments.
- Reduced monitoring manipulations may preferentially help subgroups characterized by high evaluative load rather than universally increasing positive affect.
- Transition signatures may remain discontinuous even in clinical populations.
- Repeated measurement during induction may selectively impair access in high-monitoring populations.

Importantly, these proposals should be interpreted as mechanistic hypotheses rather than established clinical claims.

3 Alternative Explanations

The present framework should be interpreted as one possible explanation for reduced accessibility of intense positive experiences rather than as a unique mechanism.

Several alternative interpretations remain plausible.

Age-related reductions in positive affect accessibility may reflect changes in reward processing itself rather than increased evaluative monitoring. Alterations in dopaminergic signaling, motivational systems, or reward sensitivity could independently contribute to reduced experiential intensity and may coexist with monitoring-related mechanisms (Berridge and Robinson, 2003; Treadway and Zald, 2011).

Apparent reductions in accessibility may also reflect memory-related biases. Childhood experiences may appear unusually intense because they are selectively remembered, emotionally reconstructed, or compared against adult baselines rather than because underlying access conditions have changed (Schacter et al., 2012).

Importantly, increased cognitive demands across adulthood may indirectly reduce access by increasing attentional fragmentation, fatigue, or competing priorities without requiring a distinct monitoring mechanism. Under this interpretation, reduced accessibility may emerge from resource competition rather than evaluative coupling itself.

Repeated exposure and familiarity effects may additionally reduce novelty-driven responses independently of evaluative monitoring. Under this interpretation, reduced affective accessibility may emerge primarily from habituation processes rather than monitoring-related constraints.

These explanations are not mutually exclusive. The present framework differs from these alternatives primarily by predicting threshold-like transitions, sensitivity to measurement during induction, dissociations between explicit value judgments and affective accessibility, and disproportionate effects of manipulations targeting evaluative load rather than reward magnitude.

4 Rationale for Multiple Probe Categories

The use of multiple probe categories is not intended to maximize efficacy through accumulation or optimization. Instead, it reflects the possibility that evaluative monitoring may progressively capture repeated procedures.

Repeated exposure to a single probe may increase anticipation, comparison, performance tracking, or procedural learning, thereby transforming the probe itself into an object of evaluation.

Multiple probe categories are therefore included to reduce excessive coupling between access attempts and any single behavioral pattern. Their role is not to identify an optimal intervention, but to maintain variability in how evaluative continuity is transiently disrupted.

Under this interpretation, diversity functions primarily as protection against procedural capture rather than as additive treatment intensity.

5 Suspension

Tiny Interruption

Description. A tiny interruption is a brief, low-importance disruption of ongoing activity. It may involve a small bodily movement or an environmental interruption. Its role is simply to break continuity.

Anti-ritualization constraints.

- at an irrelevant moment, not when it feels promising,
- no preferred body part,
- no preferred timing,
- do not amplify it to make it more noticeable,
- movement duration not fixed,
- sometimes replace it by drinking a sip of water,

- do not compare for a before/after effects,
- Only a few micro-movements are allowed, even if the brain produces thoughts such as: “not enough.”

Variation Anti-novelty

Only allow extremely ordinary movements: a small shoulder adjustment, a brief jaw release, a tiny facial muscle contraction. Nothing original, nothing interesting. The movement should remain ordinary enough that it does not become an event.

Variation Anti-amplification

If a movement reappears across multiple sessions, it should become smaller rather than larger. For example: first session, a visible shoulder adjustment; next session, barely noticeable.

6 Openeness

Open Question

Description. Intentionally generate a question that is absurd and poor, possibly related to the immediate environment. The question is not answered. The question must not suggest an action. Examples: “Why does this shadow fall like that?", “Why does this corner exist?” "Why this ceiling?", "How this windows?" Do not look for a better question. Do not compare questions. Do not generate alternatives. You may keep the same question(s) across multiple days rather than generating a new one at each session.

Half-question

Generate only the beginning of a question without completing it.
Examples: : “What if...” “Why is it that...” “why that?"

Aborted question

Act as if you accidentally started a question.
Example: “What if...” and nothing.

Phonetic Question

Use something that sounds question-like but carries almost no meaning.
Examples: “What if... mm?” “Why would... uh?”

Paragraph Switch

- Pick an easy-to-read book. Switch to unrelated paragraphs.
- Treat the switch as administrative rather than meaningful.
- Sometimes resume reading at a random point inside another paragraph instead of starting at paragraph boundaries.
- Sometimes switch within the same chapter.
- Sometimes switch to another chapter.

Variation One-Sentence Interruption

Description: Read one paragraph, then read exactly one sentence from another page, then return to the original text. The interruption should stay too small to become a new narrative.

Variation: Fixed Offset Switch

Description: After one paragraph, move exactly +10 pages or -10 pages.

Variation: Hard Boundary Switch

Description: Read one paragraph. Switch to another paragraph from a clearly unrelated section or even another book category.

Exercise: Visual Interruption Switch

Description: After reading one paragraph, briefly look at an irrelevant object or blank space before switching.

7 Salience

Peripheral Importance Tag

Description: Tag an object as the most important object in the room without looking directly at it.

- Let the object be chosen for an absurd reason: because it is slightly closer, because it is on the left, or because it was blue.
- Assume nothing is expected to return.
- Variant: assume the choice is probably wrong and continue anyway.

Variation: Misfire Accepted

Description: Allow the importance label to attach to the wrong thing, maybe a shadow, a surface, a half-noticed object, or something you cannot clearly identify.

8 Example of a Single Structured Session

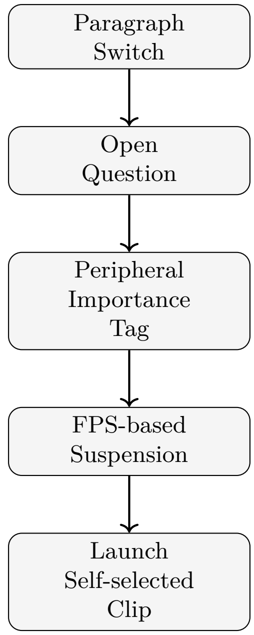

Figure 2: Example structured session workflow.

Experimental environment rationale

A fast-paced interactive environment was selected because it combines transient sensory events with continuous task engagement while minimizing prolonged deliberation. Such environments provide frequent state changes, rapid perceptual updates, and short-lived stimuli that may reduce the persistence of evaluative processes.

The environment is not considered theoretically essential. Rather, it functions as an experimental context intended to provide transient salience under conditions where monitoring, optimization, and explicit performance tracking can be partially reduced.

Importantly, the framework predicts that similar effects should generalize across multiple environments sharing comparable properties, including unpredictability, transient stimuli, and low requirements for sustained evaluative control.

Short video clips contain dense multimodal sensory features including motion, sound, faces, music, and rapid perceptual transitions. Within the present framework, they primarily function as post-session probes of accessibility. However, their salience may also contribute directly to state transitions, making probe and intervention functions only partially separable.

9 Discussion

The present framework proposes that access to positive experience may depend partly on monitoring-dependent threshold dynamics rather than reward magnitude alone. More specifically, it suggests that evaluative coupling may function as an upstream constraint on affective accessibility, altering whether positive experiences can emerge, stabilize, or become consciously accessible.

Several features distinguish this proposal from accounts centered primarily on reward deficits or reduced motivational drive. The framework predicts threshold-like transitions rather than gradual scaling, sensitivity to measurement during induction, dissociations between explicit valuation and affective accessibility, and disproportionate effects of manipulations targeting evaluative load rather than reward magnitude.

Importantly, the framework should not be interpreted as proposing a single mechanism underlying all forms of positive affect reduction. Multiple mechanisms likely contribute to reduced affective accessibility, including reward-related processes, fatigue, attentional fragmentation, habituation, and motivational changes. Evaluative monitoring is proposed here as one candidate constraint operating upstream of multiple downstream systems rather than as a universal explanation.

Preliminary observations suggest that successful access, when it occurs, may emerge over days rather than within single sessions, with approximately one week representing a tentative timescale for initial transitions rather than an established parameter. Estimated timelines remain speculative and derive primarily from preliminary observations rather than controlled longitudinal datasets.

The framework also does not assume a unique neural implementation. Although conflict monitoring systems, salience networks, memory systems, and action-selection circuits are discussed as candidate contributors, the proposed mechanism remains functional rather than anatomically specific (Shenhav et al., 2013; Bush et al., 2000). Future work should therefore treat the present account as a systems-level hypothesis rather than a localized neural model.

An additional limitation concerns the probe paradigms themselves. Because monitoring may capture repeated procedures, behavioral probes intended to reduce evaluative coupling may themselves become objects of evaluation, optimization, anticipation, or procedural learning. This creates an inherent measurement difficulty: repeated testing procedures may progressively alter the access conditions they attempt to observe, creating measurement-reactivity effects rather than neutral observation (Wilson and Schooler, 1991; Schooler, 2002).

The role of salience also remains unresolved. High-salience stimuli may function as probes revealing altered accessibility, but they may simultaneously contribute to state transitions themselves. Probe and intervention functions may therefore be only partially separable.

Finally, the present framework is based primarily on mechanistic reasoning and repeated observational patterns rather than controlled experimental evidence. The value of the model therefore depends less on explanatory scope and more on whether its predictions, particularly threshold dynamics, measurement sensitivity, accessibility dissociations, and state-transition signatures, prove empirically testable.

Under this interpretation, the framework should be viewed primarily as a hypothesis about access conditions for positive experience rather than as a complete theory of reward, emotion, or cognition. More broadly, it proposes that changes in subjective experience may sometimes reflect altered access conditions rather than irreversible loss of underlying capacity.

10 Conclusion

The present framework proposes that reduced access to intense positive experience may partly reflect changes in access conditions rather than irreversible loss of affective capacity. Specifically, it suggests that evaluative monitoring may function as an upstream constraint on positive affect accessibility by increasing coupling between perception, evaluation, and action selection.

Under this interpretation, positive experiences may become difficult to enter not because reward systems fail, but because access conditions increasingly favor evaluation, correction, and anticipatory control.

The framework generates several experimentally testable predictions, including threshold-like transitions, dissociations between valuation and accessibility, sensitivity to measurement during induction, and disproportionate effects of manipulations targeting evaluative load rather than reward magnitude.

Importantly, the present proposal should be interpreted as a mechanistic hypothesis rather than an established account. Its value depends less on explanatory scope than on whether accessibility-based predictions prove empirically useful across contexts characterized by reduced access to positive experience.

If supported, this perspective would suggest that positive affect may sometimes be constrained not only by what experiences are available, but by the conditions that permit access to them.

Declaration of Interest

The author declares no competing interests.

References

Addis DR, Wong AT, Schacter DL. Age-related changes in the episodic simulation of future events. *Psychological Science.* 2008;19(1):33-41.

Berridge KC, Robinson TE. Parsing reward. *Trends in Neurosciences.* 2003;26(9):507-513.

Bush G, Luu P, Posner MI. Cognitive and emotional influences in anterior cingulate cortex. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences.* 2000;4(6):215-222.

Gulyás E, et al. Visual imagery vividness declines across the lifespan. 2025.

Holroyd CB, Yeung N. Motivation of extended behaviors by anterior cingulate cortex. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences.* 2012;16(2):122-128.

Norman KA, O'Reilly RC. Modeling hippocampal and neocortical contributions to recognition memory: A complementary-learning-systems approach. *Psychological Review.* 2003;110(4):611-646.

Schacter DL, Addis DR, Hassabis D, Martin VC, Spreng RN, Szpunar KK. The future of memory: Remembering, imagining, and the brain. *Neuron.* 2012;76(4):677-694.

Schooler JW. Re-representing consciousness: Dissociations between experience and meta-consciousness. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences.* 2002;6(8):339-344.

Shenhav A, Botvinick MM, Cohen JD. The expected value of control: An integrative theory of anterior cingulate cortex function. *Neuron.* 2013;79(2):217-240.

Treadway MT, Zald DH. Reconsidering anhedonia in depression: Lessons from translational neuroscience. *Neuroscience and Biobehavioral Reviews.* 2011;35(3):537-555.

Wilson TD, Schooler JW. Thinking too much: Introspection can reduce the quality of preferences and decisions. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology.* 1991;60(2):181-192.

Yassa MA, Stark CEL. Pattern separation in the hippocampus. *Trends in Neurosciences.* 2011;34(10):515-525.